

THE CLOCKWORK WANDEREER



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Old analog spacecraft
had drifted together
until gravity forged
their wreckage
into a planet.

Bronze gears, golden
mechanisms, and
black ship hulls
turned beneath
my feet.

Many of the fused
vessels had belonged
to pirates, leaving
old credits and
forgotten antiques
buried inside.

I came to explore
the clockwork
world—until laser
fire revealed someone
fighting alone.



The stranger wore a slim white polymer astronaut suit, solid and sleek instead of bulky fabric.



Her mirrored helmet concealed her face, while unexplained green orbs glowed along her arms and legs.



Pink-skinned, red-eyed barbarians surrounded her with laser blasters and overwhelming strength.



Every step cracked the metal beneath them. One direct punch could have destroyed her helmet.



She carried no blaster of her own, but her cobalt gauntlets could redirect theirs.



Blue energy caught each laser blast and hurled it back toward the attackers.



Two barbarians fell, and the others fled before their own weapons could strike them.



They crossed the horizon in colossal leaps, leaving the astronaut alive—but still stranded.



I asked what had brought her to such a dangerous planet.



Treasure had brought everyone: forgotten credits and priceless relics from the analog age of space travel.



I assumed the hunters were fighting because none of them wanted to share the fortune.



The truth was more immediate. The barbarians had stolen her ship.



Without her spacecraft,
she had no ordinary
way to leave the hostile
clockwork world.



I offered to open
a portal and take her
somewhere safe.



She refused the handout,
thanked me, and insisted
that she could manage
alone.



Her answer surprised me,
but her independence
belonged to her—not
to me.



I searched for help
that would expand her
choices instead of
replacing them.



My Lucid Light became
a jetpack designed for
her suit and her
dangerous mission.



It could evade a
crushing punch, match
a barbarian's leap, or
carry her away from
the planet.



This time she accepted.
Mechanical wings
unfolded, ready to
answer only to her.



The jetpack lifted
her above the gears on
wings of metal and
Lucid Light.



She thanked me, but
she did not ask for
a rescuer, a partner,
or a sidekick.



Our crossover ended
where her next
adventure began.



The clockwork wanderer
disappeared beyond the
horizon—still mysterious,
still independent, and free
to choose her own way.

